# Yuchen Zhu

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Department of Economics, University of Florida
Gainesville, FL 32611
**Placement Director:** Ignacia Mercadal, imercadal@ufl.edu

## EDUCATION

**Ph.D. in Economics**, University of Florida — 2022 – 2027 (expected)
**M.A. in Economics**, University of Florida — 2024
**M.S. in Applied Economics**, Johns Hopkins University — 2019
**B.A. in Economics**, minor in Statistics, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign — 2017

## FIELDS

**Research:** Labor Economics, Econometrics, Applied Microeconomics

**Teaching:** Econometrics, Principles and Intermediate Microeconomics, Labor Economics, Economics of Education, Public Economics

## JOB MARKET PAPER

**Predicting College Major Switching with Machine Learning**

Major switching can benefit students, but it is costly when it happens late. Advising offices therefore want to know in advance which students are likely to switch, so they can reach out. Using administrative data from a large public university, I build a machine learning model that gives each student an unbiased and easily interpretable switching probability. I then assess which types of information drive its predictive power. Information observed at entry, such as demographics and pre-college preparation, offers little predictive power. Performance in the first few terms, especially in a major's core courses, offers substantial predictive power and predicts even switching several terms later. Advising offices can therefore identify likely switchers after a few terms, though not on arrival without new data such as surveys of students' beliefs. At the same advising capacity in each term, the model identifies 18 percent more switchers than the university's current advising system.

## WORKING PAPERS

**Migration Responses to Targeted K–12 Funding: Evidence from California's Local Control Funding Formula** [Draft]

**The Academic Effects of Performance Requirements for Staying in College Majors**
(with Robert Ainsworth, Thomas Knight, and Macy McClaren)

## WORK IN PROGRESS

**Mass Layoffs and Fertility: Evidence from WARN-Based Shocks** (with Qilin Zhang)

**Quantifying Quality Growth in China: 1988–2009** (with Qilin Zhang)

**Effect of Retirement Delay on Labor Market Supply** (with Qilin Zhang and Qiushi Hua)

## PRESENTATIONS

Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting — 2025
Workshop in Applied and Theoretical Economics (WATE), University of Florida — 2025
University of Florida Public Economics Group — 2025

## TEACHING EXPERIENCE

*Instructor of Record, University of Florida*

ECO 4421 Econometrics (Undergraduate) Spring 2026, Fall 2026

Spring 2026 evaluations (1–5 scale): overall course rating 4.47 (dept. mean 4.30); improved critical thinking 4.58 (dept. mean 4.32)

*Teaching Assistant, University of Florida*

ECO 4422 Econometrics 2 (Undergraduate) Fall 2025
ECO 5426 Econometric Analysis 1 (Graduate) Fall 2025
ECO 4104 Economics of Competitive Strategy (Undergraduate) Spring 2025
ECO 5427 Econometric Analysis 2 (Graduate) Spring 2025
ECP 6035 Cost-Benefit Analysis (Master's) Spring 2024
ECO 3101 Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergraduate) Fall 2023
ECO 4504 Public Economics (Undergraduate) Fall 2022

*Teaching Assistant, Johns Hopkins University*

Real Estate Entrepreneurship (Master's) 2018 – 2019

## Research Experience

Research Assistant to Robert Ainsworth, University of Florida Spring 2024 – Fall 2024
Research Assistant to David Sappington, University of Florida Spring 2023 – Summer 2024
Research Assistant to Javier Donna, University of Florida Spring 2023

## Other Experience

**Student Affairs Officer**, Zhejiang University, China 2020 – 2022

Managed international student services, the campus career service center, and the campus mental health center; Director of the International Student Council and the Residential College Student Committee (2021 – 2022)

## Skills

**Software:** Python, Stata, R, SQL, MATLAB, SPSS, LaTeX **Certification:** CFA Level I

**Languages:** English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native)

## References

**Robert Ainsworth** (Chair)
Department of Economics
University of Florida
robert.ainsworth@ufl.edu

**David Sappington**
Department of Economics
University of Florida
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**Cecilia Peluffo**
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